

MOSFET-Only Reference Circuit

For the MOSFET-only bias circuit, Fig. 20.12, we can write the reference current as (see Eq. [20.16])

$$I_{REF} = \frac{VDD^2 - 2VDD \cdot (V_{THN} + V_{THP}) + (V_{THN} + V_{THP})^2}{\left(\sqrt{\frac{2L_3}{KP_p \cdot W_3}} + \sqrt{\frac{2L_1}{KP_n \cdot W_1}} \right)^2} \quad (20.32)$$

Knowing $KP_n = M \cdot KP_p$, where M is 3 for our long-channel process and 2 for our short-channel process (see Tables 9.1 and 9.2), we can write

$$I_{REF} = KP_n \cdot \frac{VDD^2 - 2VDD \cdot (V_{THN} + V_{THP}) + (V_{THN} + V_{THP})^2}{\left(\sqrt{\frac{M \cdot 2L_3}{W_3}} + \sqrt{\frac{2L_1}{W_1}} \right)^2} \quad (20.33)$$

or

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial I_{REF}}{\partial T} = & \frac{\partial KP_n}{\partial T} \cdot \frac{VDD^2 - 2VDD \cdot (V_{THN} + V_{THP}) + (V_{THN} + V_{THP})^2}{\left(\sqrt{\frac{M \cdot 2L_3}{W_3}} + \sqrt{\frac{2L_1}{W_1}} \right)^2} + \\ & \frac{KP_n}{\left(\sqrt{\frac{M \cdot 2L_3}{W_3}} + \sqrt{\frac{2L_1}{W_1}} \right)^2} \cdot \left(-2VDD \cdot \left(\frac{\partial V_{THN}}{\partial T} + \frac{\partial V_{THP}}{\partial T} \right) + 2(V_{THN} + V_{THP}) \left(\frac{\partial V_{THN}}{\partial T} + \frac{\partial V_{THP}}{\partial T} \right) \right) \end{aligned} \quad (20.34)$$

Dividing both sides by Eq. (20.33) gives

$$\frac{1}{I_{REF}} \frac{\partial I_{REF}}{\partial T} = \frac{1}{KP_n} \frac{\partial KP_n}{\partial T} + \frac{2 \left(\frac{\partial V_{THN}}{\partial T} + \frac{\partial V_{THP}}{\partial T} \right) (V_{THN} + V_{THP} - VDD)}{VDD^2 - 2VDD \cdot (V_{THN} + V_{THP}) + (V_{THN} + V_{THP})^2} \quad (20.35)$$

noting, from Eq. (9.52), that the first term is simply $-1.5/T$.

Example 20.5

Determine the temperature behavior of the reference current in the MOSFET-only bias circuit seen in Fig. 20.13.

We note that both references in Fig. 20.13 have the same temperature behavior since Eq. (20.35) doesn't show a width or length dependence (there is a dependence in the reference current though). Figure 20.13 used the long-channel MOSFET parameters from Table 9.1 where

$$V_{THN} = 0.8, V_{THP} = 0.9, \frac{\partial V_{THN}}{\partial T} = -1 \text{ mV}/^\circ\text{C}, \frac{\partial V_{THP}}{\partial T} = -1.4 \text{ mV}/^\circ\text{C}$$

and $VDD = 5 \text{ V}$ with $I_{REF} = 13.5 \text{ }\mu\text{A}$ (measured in the simulation that generated Fig. 20.13) at $T = 300 \text{ K}^\circ$. Plugging the numbers into Eq. (20.35) gives

$$TCI_{REF} = \frac{1}{I_{REF}} \frac{\partial I_{REF}}{\partial T} = -\frac{1.5}{300} + \frac{2(-0.0024)(-3.3)}{25 - 17 + 2.89} = -0.005 + 0.00146 \approx -3,500 \text{ ppm}/^\circ\text{C}$$

and so $I_{REF}(T) = 13.5(1 - 0.0035(T - T_0)) \text{ }\mu\text{A}$. ■

Temperature Behavior of the Beta-Multiplier

To determine the temperature behavior of the Beta-multiplier, we take the derivative of Eq. (20.23) with respect to temperature

$$\frac{\partial I_{REF}}{\partial T} = \frac{-4}{R^3 K P_n \cdot \frac{W_1}{L_1}} \left(1 - \frac{1}{\sqrt{K}}\right)^2 \cdot \frac{\partial R}{\partial T} - \frac{2}{R^2 K P_n^2 \cdot \frac{W_1}{L_1}} \left(1 - \frac{1}{\sqrt{K}}\right)^2 \frac{\partial K P_n}{\partial T} \quad (20.36)$$

Dividing both sides by I_{REF} (Eq. [20.23]) gives

$$TCI_{REF} = \frac{1}{I_{REF}} \cdot \frac{\partial I_{REF}}{\partial T} = -2 \left(\frac{1}{R} \frac{\partial R}{\partial T} \right) - \frac{1}{K P_n} \frac{\partial K P_n}{\partial T} \quad (20.37)$$

Example 20.6

Determine the temperature behavior of the Beta-multiplier seen in Fig. 20.22.

If the temperature coefficient of the resistor, $TCR = \frac{1}{R} \frac{\partial R}{\partial T} = 2000 \text{ ppm}/^\circ\text{C}$ then

$$TCI_{REF} = -0.004 + \frac{1.5}{300} = 1000 \text{ ppm}/^\circ\text{C}$$

and so

$$I_{REF}(T) = 10 \cdot (1 + 0.001 \cdot (T - 27)) \mu\text{A}$$

The positive TC of the resistor subtracts from the negative TC of the mobility to stabilize the current reference. If the mobility change with temperature is complicated by velocity saturation effects, then simulations become invaluable to determine the actual temperature performance of the circuit. ■

Voltage Reference Using the Beta-Multiplier

Let's try designing the Beta-multiplier where the gate voltage of M1 (see Figs. 20.15 or 20.22) is a constant independent of temperature. In this type of design we aren't using this voltage directly to bias anything so we'll change the label from V_{biasn} to V_{REF} . Using Eqs. (20.22) and (20.23) gives

$$V_{REF} = V_{GS1} = \frac{2}{R \cdot K P_n \cdot \frac{W}{L}} \left(1 - \frac{1}{\sqrt{K}}\right) + V_{THN} \quad (20.38)$$

Taking the derivative with respect to temperature gives

$$\frac{\partial V_{REF}}{\partial T} = \frac{\partial V_{THN}}{\partial T} - \frac{2}{R \cdot K P_n \cdot \frac{W}{L}} \left(1 - \frac{1}{\sqrt{K}}\right) \cdot \left(\frac{1}{R} \frac{\partial R}{\partial T} + \frac{1}{K P_n} \cdot \frac{\partial K P_n}{\partial T} \right) \quad (20.39)$$

If we want the change with temperature to be zero, $\partial V_{REF}/\partial T = 0$, then we can select the resistor based on

$$R = \frac{2}{\frac{\partial V_{THN}}{\partial T} \cdot K P_n \cdot \frac{W}{L}} \left(1 - \frac{1}{\sqrt{K}}\right) \cdot \left(\frac{1}{R} \frac{\partial R}{\partial T} + \frac{1}{K P_n} \cdot \frac{\partial K P_n}{\partial T} \right) \quad (20.40)$$

Using the parameters from Table 9.1 with $K = 4$ and a resistor temperature coefficient of 0.002 gives a resistor value of 5 k Ω . Figure 20.27 shows the SPICE simulation results. The variation is approximately 60 mV/100 $^\circ\text{C}$ or 600 $\mu\text{V}/^\circ\text{C}$.

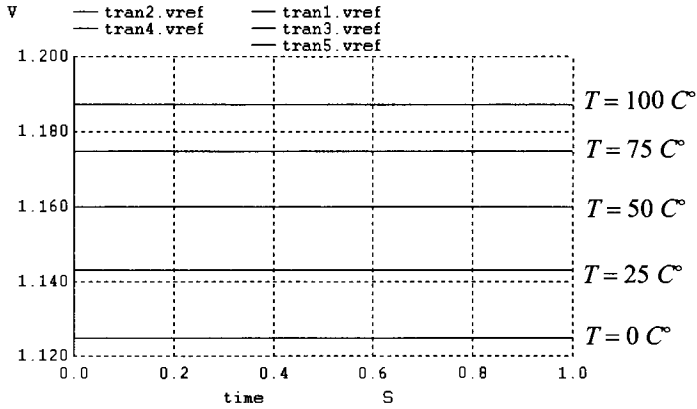


Figure 20.27 Temperature performance of a voltage reference using the Beta-multiplier.

20.1.6 Biasing in the Subthreshold Region

In some CMOS designs (for example, low-power designs) the MOSFETs may be operated in the weak or subthreshold regions. If a resistor is used to bias a current mirror, as seen in Fig. 20.10, its value can be very large. For example, if we use the short-channel process with $V_{DD} = 1$ V and a V_{SG} of approximately V_{THP} ($= 280$ mV) with an I_D of 10 nA, we need a resistor with a value of

$$I_{REF} = \frac{V_{DD} - V_{SG}}{R} \rightarrow R = 72 \text{ M}\Omega ! \quad (20.41)$$

Clearly, this isn't practical. To bias circuits for subthreshold operation, let's use the Beta-multiplier. From Eq. (9.17) we can write

$$V_{GS1} = nV_T \cdot \ln\left(\frac{I_{REF} \cdot L_1}{I_{D0} \cdot W_1}\right) + V_{THN} \quad (20.42)$$

and

$$V_{GS2} = nV_T \cdot \ln\left(\frac{I_{REF} \cdot L_1}{I_{D0} \cdot K \cdot W_1}\right) + V_{THN} \quad (20.43)$$

Knowing

$$I_{REF} = \frac{V_{GS1} - V_{GS2}}{R} \quad (20.44)$$

we get

$$I_{REF} = \frac{n \cdot V_T}{R} \cdot \ln K \quad (20.45)$$

or

$$R = \frac{n \cdot V_T}{I_{REF}} \cdot \ln K \quad (20.46)$$

Using the values above, that is, $K = 4$ and an I_{REF} of 10 nA, gives an R (assuming $n = 1$) of approximately 3.5 M Ω . Still large but much better than 72 M Ω .

20.2 Cascoding the Current Mirror

In this section we discuss increasing the output resistance of a current mirror so that it behaves more ideally. Figure 20.28 shows the problem with using a single MOSFET for a current source. Instead of being a constant, the output current, I_O , increases as the voltage across the current source, V_O , increases. We model this increase using the MOSFET's output resistance, r_o (see Table 9.2). If we can hold the drain-source voltage of the MOSFET constant, then the current doesn't vary. However, this requires a fixed V_O . To avoid this, we'll add circuitry in between the current-mirrored MOSFET and V_O .

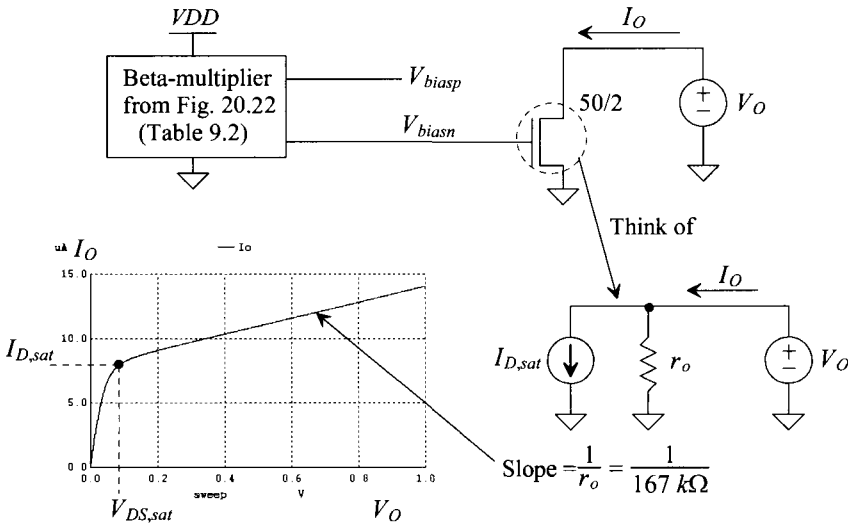


Figure 20.28 How the finite output resistance of the MOSFET affects the output current.

20.2.1 The Simple Cascode

The simple cascode current mirror made with M1–M4 is seen in Fig. 20.29. The name “cascode” is a vestige from the days of vacuum tubes when a common-cathode amplifier was cascaded (in series with) a common-grid amplifier. Drawing an analogy with MOSFETs, the cathode of a tube is equivalent to the source of a MOSFET. The grid of a tube corresponds to the gate of a MOSFET and the anode to the drain of the MOSFET.

It's important to realize that I_O is still determined by the gate-source voltages of M1 and M2. Changing the sizes of M3 and M4 simply changes the drain-source voltages of M1/M2, affecting the matching of their drain currents, as indicated by Eq. (20.10). Again, this (the gate-source voltages of M1/M2 determine the currents) is important to understand since, in the next several pages, we present different modifications to this basic cascode circuit. These modifications attempt to hold the drain source voltages of M1/M2 more constant to increase the current mirror's output resistance (make I_O change less with changes in V_O).

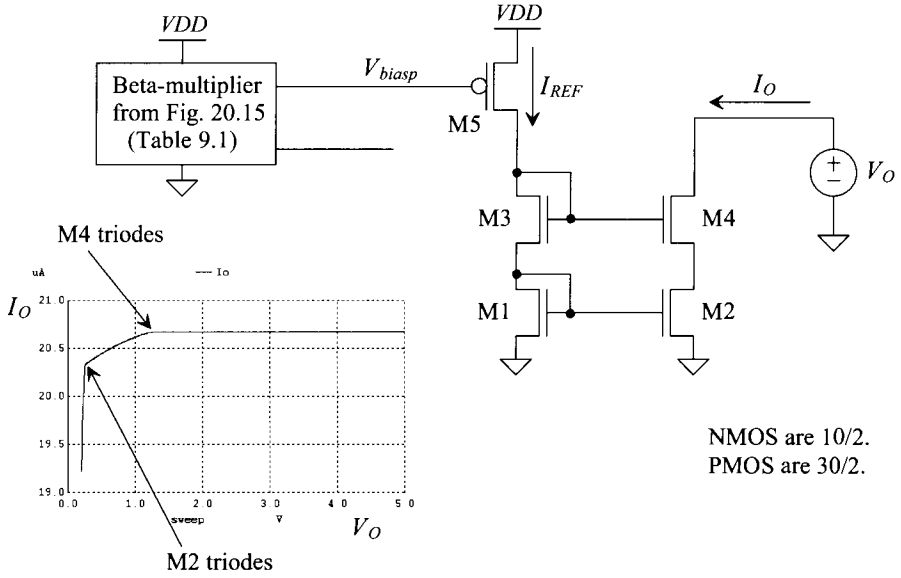


Figure 20.29 Biasing of the cascode current source and its operation.

DC Operation

The voltage on the gate of M4 in Fig. 20.29 is (remembering the actual values for these specific biasing conditions is given in Table 9.1)

$$2V_{GS} = 2(V_{DS,sat} + V_{THN}) \quad (20.47)$$

The voltage on the drain of M2, assuming that it is operating in the saturation region, is V_{GS} . The minimum voltage across the current source is then

$$V_{O,min} = V_{DS,sat4} + V_{GS} = 2V_{DS,sat} + V_{THN} \quad (20.48)$$

Plugging in the numbers from Table 9.1, we get $V_{O,min} = 1.3 \text{ V}$. Reviewing Fig. 20.29, we see that M4 starts to move into the triode region at this voltage.

To keep both M2 and M4 operating in the saturation region, we need only a $V_{DS,sat}$ across each one. In the next section we'll use this fact to design a *low-voltage cascode* current mirror.

Cascode Output Resistance

To estimate the output resistance of the cascode current mirror, let's apply a test voltage to the simplified cascode schematic seen in Fig. 20.30. We treat M1 and M3 as DC bias sources (AC grounds) and assume that the DC voltage on the drain of M4 is large enough to ensure that M2 and M4 are operating in the saturation. Further we draw the output resistances external to the devices. Note that M2's AC gate source voltage is zero and its drain voltage is $-v_{gs4}$. The resistance seen looking into the drain of M4 is

$$R_o = \frac{v_T}{i_T} \quad (20.49)$$

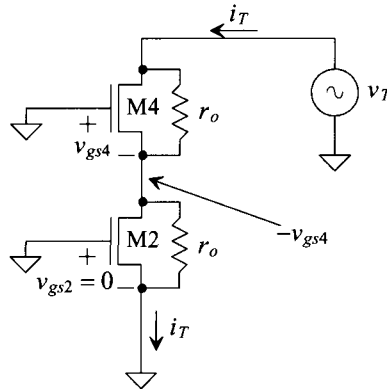


Figure 20.30 AC circuit used to determine the output resistance of a cascode current source.

Looking at Fig. 20.30, we can write

$$-v_{gs4} = i_T \cdot r_o \quad (20.50)$$

The current through M4 is then

$$i_T = g_m v_{gs4} + \frac{v_T - (-v_{gs4})}{r_o} \quad (20.51)$$

Substituting (20.50) into (20.51) gives

$$i_T = g_m(-i_T \cdot r_o) + \frac{v_T}{r_o} - i_T \quad (20.52)$$

Solving for the output resistance

$$R_o = (2 + g_m r_o) r_o \approx g_m r_o^2 \quad (20.53)$$

This result should be remembered because it will be referred to often. Using the numbers from Tables 9.1 and 9.2, we can tabulate the output resistance of cascode structures as seen in Table 20.1.

Table 20.1 Output resistances for cascode structures.

Cascode type	Long-channel process, Table 9.1, R_o	Short-channel process, Table 9.2, R_o
PMOS	2.4 G Ω	16.6 M Ω
NMOS	3.75 G Ω	4.2 M Ω

Notice the large difference (almost three orders of magnitude) between the output resistance of the short- and the long-channel devices. Again, this is the reason we need to use special circuit techniques when designing in short-channel processes.

Finally, note that the output resistance can be determined from a plot like the one seen in Fig. 20.29 (or Fig. 20.28) by plotting the reciprocal of the derivative of the output current.

20.2.2 Low-Voltage (Wide-Swing) Cascode

Figure 20.31a shows the regularly biased cascode structure. The key point of this figure is that the drain of M2 is not at the minimum voltage required to keep it in saturation, $V_{DS,sat}$, but rather it is held at a threshold voltage above this minimum. In (b) the cascode is biased for lowest voltage operation. What this means is that the drain of M4, V_o , can go to the minimum possible voltage that keeps M2/M4 in saturation, that is, $2V_{DS,sat}$. Again, it's important to notice that the gate-source voltages of M1/M2 are what set the currents in the mirror.

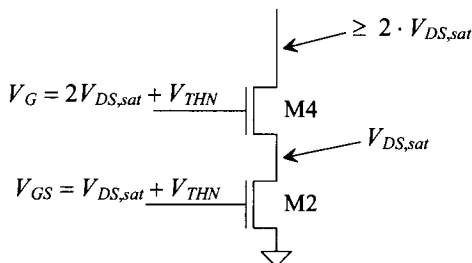
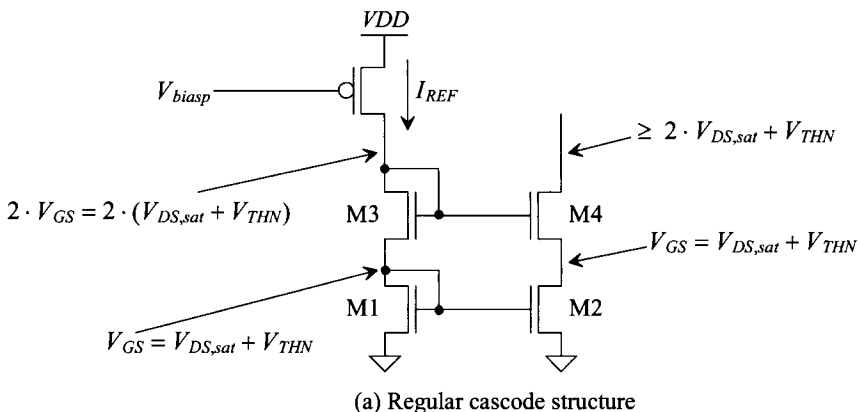


Figure 20.31 DC voltages in (a) a cascode current mirror and in (b) a low-voltage cascode.

To generate the gate voltage of M2, we simply use a diode-connected MOSFET as seen in almost every schematic in this chapter. From Eq. (20.1), for example, we can write

$$I_{REF} = \frac{KP_n}{2} \cdot \frac{W}{L} (V_{GS} - V_{THN})^2 \quad (20.54)$$

neglecting channel-length modulation. To generate the bias voltage for M4, we can adjust the width and length of a MOSFET, MWS, as seen in Fig. 20.32. We can write, knowing $V_{DS,sat} = V_{GS} - V_{THN}$

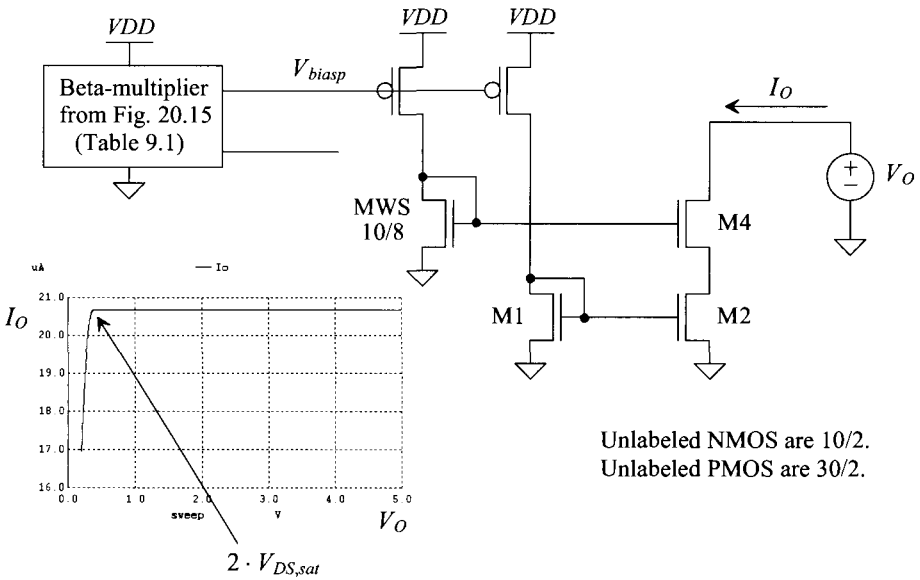


Figure 20.33 Wide-swing cascode current source in the long-channel process.

An Important Practical Note

In general we won't design a wide-swing current sink by setting the length to four times the length used in the rest of the design. As just mentioned, this biases M2 right on the edge of the triode region (point A) in Fig. 20.34. Stealing a current from the drain of M2 will move M2 into the triode region, point B. If we bias M2 further into the saturation region, point C, then more current must be removed before M2 triodes and the output resistance of the current source decreases. When we design folded-cascode amplifiers later, we will steal or add current in this way. For general *long-channel design*, we'll use

$$\frac{W_{MWS}}{L_{MWS}} = \frac{1}{5} \cdot \frac{W}{L} \quad (20.59)$$

or using the same widths then

$$L_{MWS} = 5 \cdot L \quad (20.60)$$

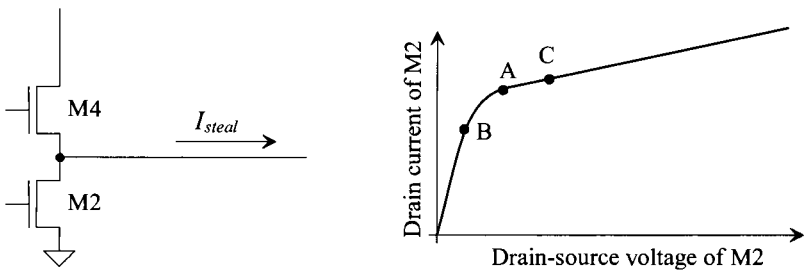


Figure 20.34 Showing how stealing current from M2 moves it into the triode region.

Layout Concerns

When we go to layout the long L device seen in Fig. 20.32, we might simply layout a single MOSFET with the appropriate length. However, the threshold voltage can vary significantly with the length of the device. Figure 20.35 shows a method where MOSFETs connected in series with the same widths and their gates tied together behave like a single MOSFET with the sum of the individual MOSFET's lengths. Because each device is identical, changes in the threshold voltage shouldn't affect the biasing circuit.

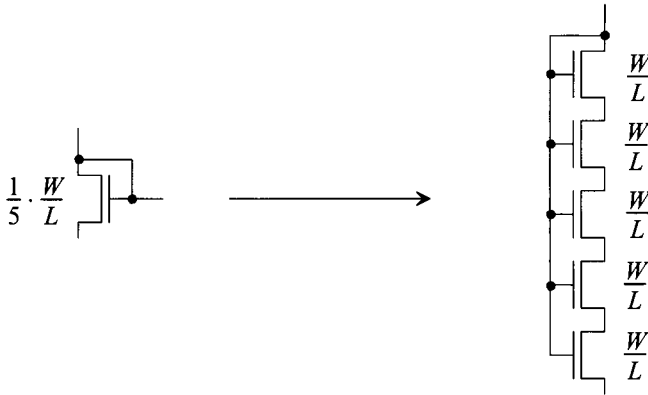


Figure 20.35 Using equal length devices to implement a long L MOSFET.

20.2.3 Wide-Swing, Short-Channel Design

When designing a wide-swing current mirror in a short-channel CMOS process, we know

$$V_{DS,sat} \neq V_{GS} - V_{THN} = V_{ovn} \quad (20.61)$$

Further, as seen in Fig. 9.32 in Ch. 9, the output resistance of a short-channel MOSFET depends on the drain-to-source voltage. Figure 20.36 shows a wide-swing current mirror designed in the short-channel CMOS process (see Table 9.2). Note that the current is approximately $4 \mu\text{A}$ when it should be, as seen in Fig. 20.23, $10 \mu\text{A}$. Further, if we were to measure the output resistance, we would get approximately 600k , which is considerably less than the $4 \text{ M}\Omega$ seen in Table 20.1. As seen in Fig. 9.32, the output resistance at $V_{DS,sat}$ isn't 166k as indicated in Table 9.2 but much less. To increase the output resistance, let's attempt to bias M2 deeper into the saturation region. Let's do this by using a larger value of voltage on the gate of M4. For our short-channel design, let's try

$$\frac{W_{MWS}}{L_{MWS}} = \frac{1}{25} \cdot \frac{W}{L} \quad (20.62)$$

or a five times smaller ratio than what we used for the long-channel devices (Eq. [20.59]). The simulation results for the circuit in Fig. 20.36 are seen in Fig. 20.37 when MWS is sized 10/10. Notice that our output current is closer to $10 \mu\text{A}$. Studying Fig. 20.36 and remembering our constant theme in this chapter that good matching requires both equal V_{GS} and V_{DS} , we see a concern. M1's drain-to-source voltage isn't the same as M2's. By

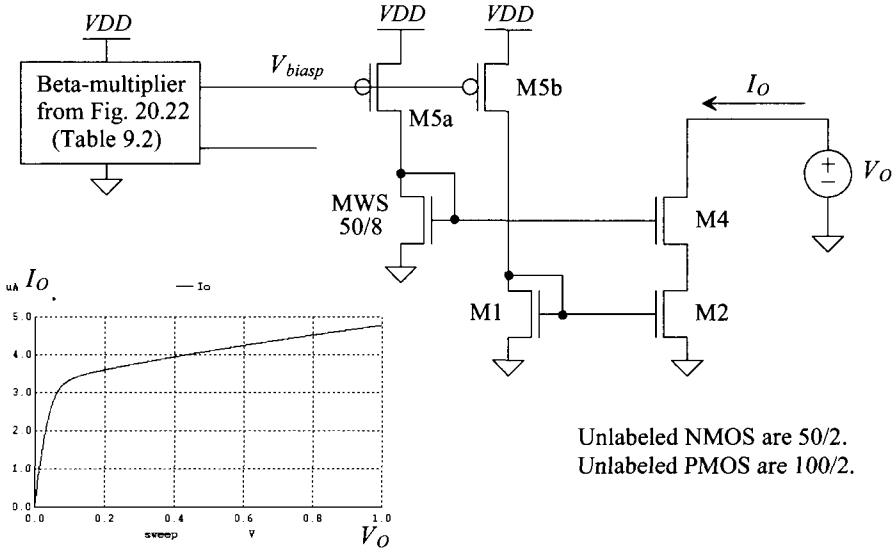


Figure 20.36 Wide-swing cascode current source in the short-channel process (bad).

making the gate voltage of M4 larger, we act to equalize the two drain-to-source voltages (we increase the drain voltage of M2) causing the output current to approach the current that flows in M1 (10 μ A). Let's attempt to make the current mirrors more symmetrical in an effort to equilibrate the drain-to-source voltages of M1 and M2.

Figure 20.38 shows the addition of a MOSFET, M3, to lower M1's V_{DS} so that it matches M2's V_{DS} . The 10 μ A current through M5b can now be mirrored accurately. M1's gate voltage increases until M1 (and thus M2) can sink the current supplied by M5b with the smaller V_{DS} . *For all wide-swing current mirrors the topology seen in Fig. 20.38 using M3 should be used.* Note also, in Fig. 20.38, the larger voltage needed across the current source to keep M2/M4 saturated. The drains of M1 and M2 are at 150 mV or considerably above $V_{DS,sat}$ (which is 50 mV from Fig. 9.32). M3 is moving close to the triode region. Equation (20.62) can be modified to move M3 away from triode by using a larger W/L device (say 1/10); however, the output resistance will decrease (again as seen in Fig. 9.32, the decrease in V_{DS} results in smaller output resistance, r_o).

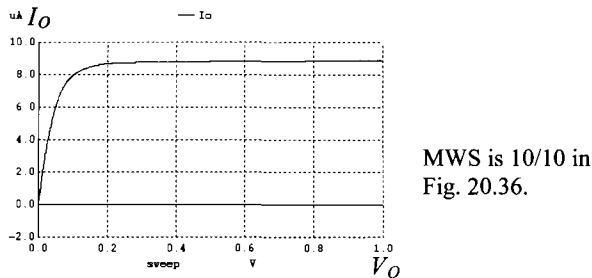


Figure 20.37 Increasing the W/L of MWS to 1/25 the other W/Ls.